Case Study: The "Urgent" Executive – A Business Email Compromise Scenario

The Crime: Business Email Compromise

Business Email Compromise is a kind of cyber fraud that's very tricky. It is not like phishing where lots of people get fake emails. Business Email Compromise is when a bad person pretends to be a high-level executive or someone the company trusts. They do this to trick an employee into sending money or giving away company information.

The Anatomy of the Attack: Step-by-Step

First the bad person does a lot of research on the company. They use LinkedIn and the company website to find out who the Chief Financial Officer is and who is in charge of paying the bills.

Next the bad person makes an email address that looks like it is from the company. They might even get into the executive real email account.

Then they send an email to the person in charge of money. The email says something like "this urgent and secret" and claims the company is buying another company. It says a vendor needs $45,000 away.

The bad person writes the email in a way that sounds professional but a little mean. They say the money has to be sent within one hour or there will be problems.

The employee is scared of getting in trouble at work. So, they do not follow the rules to make sure everything is okay. They just send the money to the persons account in another country.

The Target

Any company can be a target. The bad people usually go after medium to large companies that do business all around the world. They like to trick people who work with money like those in the finance or human resources departments.

The Consequences

When this happened, the company loses a lot of money. Usually, they cannot get the money back once it is sent to another country. The company also looks bad to people. They might even get sued by their partners. The employees do not trust each other anymore. The person who was tricked feels very stressed out. Might even lose their job.

Real-World Reference: The Federal Bureau of Investigation says that Business Email Compromise is one of the expensive online crimes. Over the ten years companies all around the world have lost more, than $50 billion because of it.